

The Fairest of Them All

An eagle once promised an owl in **return for a favour**, that he would never harm the owl's **chicks**.

"But do you know what my chicks look like?" asked the mother owl. "How can I be sure that you won't mistake them for some other bird's?"



"Well," said the eagle. "Describe them to me, so that I can **recognize** them.

"Actually, they cannot be mistaken for any other bird's," said the owl proudly. "They are soft, **fluffy**, and **by far** the prettiest young ones you could ever see."

One evening, the eagle came upon a nest filled with **screeching fledglings**. He thought, "Surely these are not the owl's chicks. She said they are very beautiful, but these chicks look **hideous**." And he **swooped down** and ate them all.

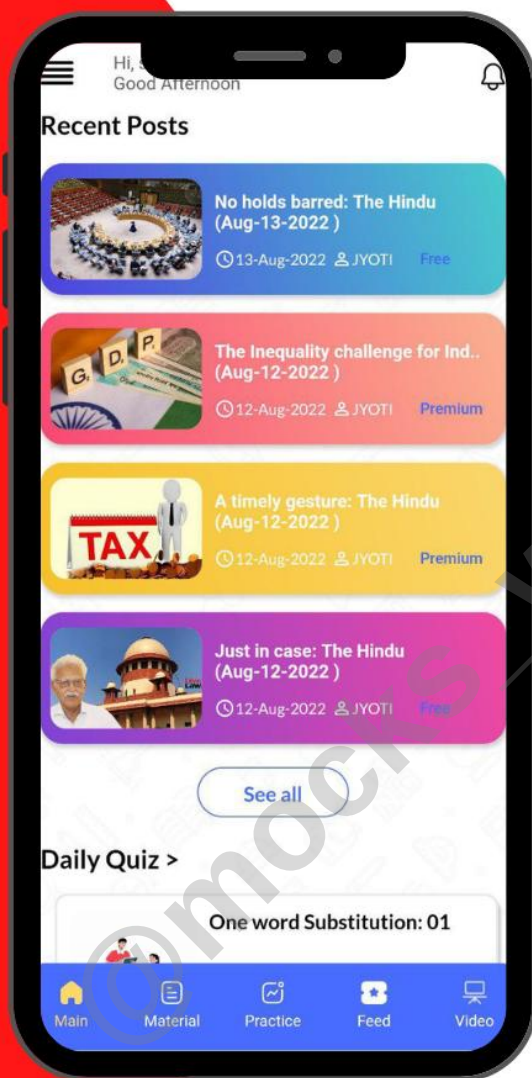
Returning to her nest, the mother owl found it empty.

"How could the eagle have forgotten his promise?" she **wailed**. "I told him my chicks were the most beautiful in the world!"

Moral: Every mother thinks that her own children are the best.

Vocabulary

1. **Return for the favour** (phrase) – to do something the same or similar in return for something done बदले में
2. **Chick** (noun) – baby bird, fledgling, nestling, hatchling, juvenile bird चूजा
3. **Recognize** (verb) – identify, distinguish, acknowledge, know, spot पहचानना
4. **Fluffy** (adjective) – soft, feathery, downy, fuzzy, woolly फूला हुआ / मुलायम
5. **By far** (phrase) – undoubtedly, definitely, considerably, unquestionably, clearly अब तक / निस्संदेह
6. **Screeching** (adjective) – shrieking, squawking, squealing, howling, yelling चीखता हुआ
7. **Fledgling** (noun) – young bird, baby bird, nestling, juvenile, chick नवजात पक्षी
8. **Hideous** (adjective) – ugly, horrible, dreadful, repulsive, grotesque डरावना / भयंकर
9. **Swoop down** (phrasal verb) – dive, pounce, descend, plunge, strike नीचे झपटना
10. **Wail** (verb) – cry, lament, howl, sob, moan विलाप करना



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